

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay (Social Media)

1. What is a one-sided argumentative essay for?

Purpose

- To persuade a reader who does not yet agree with you, by presenting ONE clear side of a debatable issue with reasons, evidence and examples.
- Your job is not to report both sides (that is a discussion essay). Your job is to make one side look right and to answer the best objection to it.

Target audience — the reader named in the question: the editor of the school magazine, your fellow students, a debating audience or the general public (in a letter to the editor).

Real-life examples

School magazine article — “Do smartphones do more harm than good to students?”

Letter to the editor — “Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?”

Debate speech — “This house believes that social media harms teenagers.”

Blog / online forum post — “Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?”

How this differs from Part A (a proposal)

- A proposal = a plan and a request for approval. An argumentative essay = an opinion and a request for agreement.
- Both are formal, but there is one register switch to teach: an argumentative essay may use “I firmly believe that ...” to state a stance, whereas a proposal should stay impersonal throughout.
- Never use “you” in either text type. Replace “you” with “teenagers”, “students” or “young people”.

What the marker is looking for — three things only: (i) relevant, well-developed content; (ii) visible organisation, i.e. signposting and one argument per paragraph; (iii) accurate, wide-ranging language, including the Unit 6 vocabulary.

2. Sample writing & structural elements

Read the sample once, then look at the right-hand column to see how each part is built.

*Legend — **GREEN** = signposting device (the marker's map). **RED** = Unit 6 target vocabulary. Numbers in brackets = the recommended word budget for each move.*

Question: You have read an article claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an article for the school magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words)

Article: Social Media — More Harm Than Good Introduction Six hours a day. That is how long the average Hong Kong teenager spends on social media — time that could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply	Structure 1. Title • name the issue and take a side (“Social Media — More Harm
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talking to family. Social media is now **ubiquitous**, and although it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. **I firmly believe that** social media does more harm than good to teenagers.

Body 1 — Argument 1

First and foremost, social media is **detrimental to** teenagers' mental health. Platforms are engineered to reward comparison, so users are **inundated with** polished photographs of other people's holidays, friendships and achievements, and they are quietly nudged to measure their own ordinary lives against this fiction. A student who has just failed a test may open her phone and be reminded, within seconds, of a classmate's success. Repeated daily, this comparison **erodes** self-esteem and **exacerbates** the anxiety that many teenagers already carry, and the harm is **insidious** precisely because it feels so normal.

Body 2 — Argument 2

Moreover, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention **fragmented**, and **fragmented** attention makes deep reading — the very skill that public examinations demand — almost impossible to sustain. A student who revises with an active group chat is not really revising; she is merely alternating between two tasks and performing both badly. **Worse still**, late-night scrolling delays sleep, which in turn **undermines** the concentration a student needs in class the next morning.

Body 3 — Counter-argument & rebuttal

Some may argue that social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. **Admittedly**, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a student with a niche interest may find an online community that her own school cannot offer. **However**, these benefits are **superficial** when set against the costs. Connectivity available at every hour of the day is precisely what makes it so hard to switch off, and a following built on fleeting likes is rarely **reciprocal** support; it is, at best, an **ephemeral** substitute for friendship. **To put it bluntly**, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm **compounds** year after year.

Conclusion

In conclusion, social media is not without value, yet its effects on teenagers' well-being, concentration and self-image plainly outweigh its benefits. **The answer is not** an outright ban, which would be **counterproductive**, **but** a deliberate effort to **curb** the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen deserves their attention.

Than Good")

2. Introduction

(≈60 words)

- Hook — a striking figure, a short question or a vivid image
- Narrow the focus — how does this touch us? (teenagers, our school)
- Stance — ONE side, stated openly. Never both.
- Signals — I firmly believe that / It is undeniable that / Clearly,

3. Body arguments

— *two paragraphs*
(≈85 words each)

- ONE argument per paragraph. Never two.
- Two arguments are enough for 400 words; a third only if the limit allows
- Topic sentence = signpost + the argument itself
- Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain, not a list
- Example — a named scenario (a Form 5 student, a survey, a news story)
- Round off — echo the key words of the question
- Signals — First and foremost, / Moreover, / Worse still,

4. Counter-argument & rebuttal (≈100 words)

- Concede fairly — Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...
- Rebut — However, ... + why the

(406 words)

Teacher's Note: the sample argues the HARMFUL side. For the enthusiastic class that wants the opposite stance, the same skeleton works unchanged — keep the counter-argument paragraph, concede the harms, rebut with the benefits (access to information, community for isolated students, creative self-expression), and swap the vocabulary for **democratise, indispensable, bolster, conducive, tangible**.

objection fails

- Re-sharpen your own side, harder than before
- This paragraph is what separates a solid pass from a top-band script

5. Conclusion (≈55 words)

- Restate the stance in NEW words
- Summarise the arguments in one line
- Final thought — a warning, a recommendation or a call to action

6. The whole essay in one line

[Stance] →
[Argument 1] →
[Argument 2] →
[Counter + Rebuttal] →
[Restate]

Word budget used above: 65 + 92 + 75 + 112 + 62 = 406

3. Language features — poor vs upgraded

Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing — only the language changes. Bold words in the upgraded example are the target items.

Rule of thumb: B1 "topic sentence + example" writing becomes B3 writing the moment the cause-and-effect chain is explicit and the signposts do real work.

Feature (rule)	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
One side only <i>take a stance in the introduction and never wobble</i>	Social media has advantages and disadvantages, so I will talk about both.	Although social media is not without value, its effects on teenagers are far more harmful than helpful.
A stance the marker can find <i>the stance must appear in the introduction, in one sentence</i>	Social media is a very popular topic nowadays. Many people talk about it.	Social media is now ubiquitous, and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves. I firmly believe that it does more harm than good to teenagers.
Topic sentence + signposting	Another thing I want to say is that using phones is	Moreover, the damage reaches beyond feelings

<i>every body</i> <i>paragraph opens</i> <i>with its argument,</i> <i>not a filler sentence</i>	bad for studying.	into academic performance.
Cause-and-effect chains <i>link ideas with so / because / which leads to — do not stack short statements</i>	Students use their phones a lot. They cannot concentrate. Their results are bad.	Every notification leaves attention fragmented, and fragmented attention makes deep reading almost impossible to sustain.
Concede, then rebut <i>the “Level 5” move: give the other side its due, then defeat it</i>	Some people think social media is good, but I do not agree with them.	Admittedly, a group chat can help a class organise a project; however, these benefits are superficial when set against the costs.
Formal, impersonal tone <i>no “you”, no slang, no “super / stuff / a lot of things”</i>	You can see that everyone is glued to their phones these days, which is super bad.	It is undeniable that smartphone dependency has become widespread among young people, and the consequences are serious.
Hedged claims <i>avoid absolutes — “every”, “all”, “always”, “destroys”</i>	Social media destroys every teenager’s life and makes them all depressed.	Excessive use is likely to erode teenagers’ self-esteem and to exacerbate the anxiety they already carry.
Precise, topic-specific vocabulary <i>use the Unit 6 items instead of problem / bad / thing</i>	Social media gives students a lot of problems and bad feelings.	Social media compounds the pressure teenagers feel and undermines their confidence.

4. Vocabulary upgrade (Unit 6 — Communication & Technology)

Same meaning, higher band. Teach the LEFT column first, then let students find the right-hand version themselves.

Teacher’s Tip: project only the left column, ask the class for a “more formal” version, and only then reveal the right-hand column. The words stick when students have already reached for them.

	Informal/Basic	Formal
1.	social media is everywhere now	social media is now ubiquitous
2.	it makes the problem worse	it exacerbates / compounds the problem
3.	it slowly damages students’ confidence	it erodes students’ self-esteem
4.	students get far too much information	students are inundated with posts and notifications
5.	students cannot concentrate on one thing	constant alerts leave students’ attention fragmented

6.	the harm is hard to notice at first	the harm is insidious
7.	it is bad for teenagers' health	it is detrimental to teenagers' health
8.	students cannot stop checking their phones	phone-checking has become an unsustainable habit
9.	social media makes us care less about serious things	social media desensitises users to serious issues
10.	the good points are only on the surface	the benefits are superficial and ephemeral
11.	friendships online are not really two-way	friendships online are rarely reciprocal
12.	one rumour can reach thousands of people quickly	a single post can amplify a rumour within minutes
13.	we should limit our screen time	we should curb our screen time
14.	we can use social media for studying	we can harness social media for learning

Unit 6 vocabulary used in the sample — where and how

Unit 6 word	Pattern it takes	Where it appears
ubiquitous (adj)	be ubiquitous among young people / in our daily lives	Introduction
detrimental (adj)	be detrimental to + noun	Body 1
inundate (v)	be inundated with + noun	Body 1
erode (v)	erode + self-esteem / trust / confidence	Body 1
exacerbate (v)	exacerbate + a problem / anxiety	Body 1
insidious (adj)	an insidious effect / an insidious form of harm	Body 1
fragmented (adj)	leave attention / attention span fragmented	Body 2
undermine (v)	undermine + concentration / confidence / trust	Body 2
superficial (adj)	superficial benefits / superficial understanding	Body 3
reciprocal (adj)	reciprocal support / a reciprocal relationship	Body 3
ephemeral (adj)	ephemeral fame / an ephemeral friendship	Body 3
compound (v)	compound + a problem / the pressure on students	Body 3
counterproductive (adj)	be counterproductive / prove counterproductive	Conclusion
curb (v)	curb + screen time / spending / the habit	Conclusion
<i>Swap-in words for other topics: proliferate, impede, stifle, jeopardise, perpetuate, alienate, intrusive, conducive, indispensable, bolster, tangible, unsustainable</i>		

5. Signposting & sentence-stem bank (the green items)	
<i>Four or five of these per essay is enough. Mechanical “Firstly ... Secondly ... Thirdly ... Lastly” without a topic sentence adds nothing.</i>	
Function	Sentence stems
Introduce the issue (hook)	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous in our daily lives. It is undeniable that ... Why do so many of us ...? One striking figure stands out: ...
State your stance	I firmly believe that ... I am convinced that ... It is clear that ... There is little doubt that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ... To begin with, ...
Add arguments	Moreover, ... Furthermore, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is the fact that ...
Give an example	For instance, ... Consider a Form 5 student who ... A case in point is ... Take the way ... , for example.
Concede	Admittedly, ... It is true that ... Some may argue that ... Those who defend ... point out that ...
Rebut	However, ... This argument, though reasonable, overlooks ... Even so, ... What such a view ignores is ...
Conclude	In conclusion, ... On balance, ... The evidence therefore suggests that ...
Final thought	The answer is not to ... but to ... Unless we act now, ... It is high time that we ...

6. Writing practice — one-sided argumentative essay
Situation
Your school is considering banning smartphones on campus during school hours. The editor of the school magazine has invited students to write in and argue their case. Should smartphones be banned on campus? Write an article for the school magazine arguing either for or against the ban. (about 400 words)
Your task
1. Decide your stance — ONE side only, and make it visible in the introduction. 2. Choose TWO reasons — one per body paragraph. (For the ban: distraction in lessons, cyberbullying that continues in school, damage to face-to-face friendship. Against the ban: contacting parents in an emergency, learning apps and dictionaries in class, building responsible habits.) 3. Include one counter-argument paragraph that ends with a rebuttal — this is the paragraph that earns the top-band marks. 4. Use at least SIX words from Section 4 and at least FOUR signposting devices from Section 5. 5. Plan first (5 minutes), then write about 400 words.

Planning scaffold — complete the right-hand column before writing

Part of the essay	Your plan
Introduction	Hook: _____ • How it touches us: _____ _____ • Stance: _____ • Signal: _____

Body 1 — reason 1	Topic sentence: _____ • Cause → effect: _____ • Example: _____
Body 2 — reason 2	Topic sentence: _____ • Cause → effect: _____ • Example: _____
Body 3 — counter-argument & rebuttal	Concede (Admittedly, ...): _____ • Rebut (However, ...): _____ • Re-sharpen: _____
Conclusion	Restated stance (new words): _____ • Summary line: _____ • Final thought: _____

Answer key — teacher's plan for the practice question (arguing FOR the ban)

Introduction	• Hook: "A single buzz can end a lesson." / a phone-free Tuesday. • Stance: the school should ban smartphones during school hours. • Signals: It is undeniable that ... , I firmly believe that ...
Body 1 — learning	• Topic sentence: Moreover, a phone-free campus protects the attention that learning demands. • Cause → effect: notifications → fragmented attention → deep reading impossible → weaker exam performance. • Example: a Form 5 student revising beside a live group chat. • Unit 6: fragmented, undermine, impede, conducive
Body 2 — well-being	• Topic sentence: Worse still, school-hour phone use feeds the very harm schools exist to prevent. • Cause → effect: online comparison and cyberbullying continue inside the classroom → anxiety, eroded self-esteem. • Example: a mocking comment passed round a class group chat during lunch. • Unit 6: detrimental, erode, exacerbate, desensitise
Body 3 — counter & rebuttal	• Concede: Admittedly, a smartphone lets parents reach a child in an emergency. • Rebut: However, the general office has always relayed urgent messages, so safety does not depend on a phone in a pocket. • Re-sharpen: keeping phones in lockers, not in hands, is the reasonable middle way.
Conclusion	• Restate: a phone-free campus protects learning and friendships rather than punishing students. • Final thought: responsibility is taught by example, not by assuming it exists.

Model paragraph 1 — Body paragraph (Argument 1)

Move tags: (1) signpost + topic sentence (2) cause-and-effect explanation (3) named scenario (4) round off back to the question.

First and foremost, a phone-free campus protects the attention that learning demands. Every alert leaves attention **fragmented**, and **fragmented** attention makes the deep reading that public examinations require almost impossible to sustain. Consider a Form 5 student revising for her mock examination while a class group chat buzzes beside her textbook: she is not revising at all, but alternating between two tasks and performing both badly. In the long run, such habits **undermine** the concentration that a single quiet hour would have built. (83 words)

Model paragraph 2 — counter-argument & rebuttal

Move tags: (1) concede fairly (2) rebut with a concrete reason (3) re-sharpen the stance. Note that the rebuttal answers the objection — it does not simply repeat the writer’s opinion.

Some may argue that banning phones is unfair, since parents need to reach their children in an emergency. **Admittedly**, a smartphone offers immediate contact, and no reasonable school should dismiss that concern. **However**, the argument proves far less than it appears to: schools have always relayed urgent messages through the general office, and a parent who needs a child at once can telephone the school directly. **What the objection overlooks** is that the same device that carries one emergency call also carries a hundred trivial ones, which is precisely why phone-checking has become an **unsustainable** habit for so many teenagers. The ban, then, gives up very little of real value. (110 words)

For marker’s use — tick only what the script actually does

- ☐ Stance stated clearly in the introduction — one side only
- ☐ Two or three distinct reasons, one per body paragraph (no disguised repetition)
- ☐ Topic sentence at the start of every body paragraph
- ☐ At least one concrete example or named scenario
- ☐ A counter-argument paragraph that ends with a rebuttal
- ☐ Conclusion restates the stance in new words and adds a final thought
- ☐ At least six Unit 6 words used accurately
- ☐ At least four signposting devices from Section 5
- ☐ Formal register — no “you”, no slang, no repetition of “I think”
- ☐ About 400 words, with tense and subject-verb agreement checked

Common weaknesses & teacher’s tips

Fence-sitting. “On the one hand ... on the other hand” cancels the one-sided requirement. Fix: choose the side at the planning stage, and let the other side appear only in the counter-argument paragraph.

Repetition in disguise. Three paragraphs that all say “it wastes time” earn no extra content marks. Fix: label each paragraph with one noun before writing — learning, health, friendship, safety, privacy.

Abstract arguments with no example. Fix: teach the named-scenario formula — a Form 5 student, a Tuesday evening, a buzzing group chat.

Invented statistics. Do not let students make up surveys or figures. Use the data the question supplies, or use a hypothetical scenario instead.

Signposts that carry nothing. “Firstly, Secondly, Lastly” with no topic sentence is decoration, not organisation. Every signpost must be followed immediately by the argument itself.

A conclusion that copies the introduction. Fix: paraphrase — change the wording, keep the stance.

Teacher’s Tip: the counter-argument paragraph is the cheapest way to lift a script from a solid pass to a top band. Drill it as a fixed three-sentence formula: concede (Admittedly, ...) → rebut (However, ...) → re-sharpen (What this overlooks is ...).